

Musical markings

Composers need to give instructions to musicians on how to perform their musical pieces. Terms and symbols printed on the score relay this information to the performers, who then translate the written notation into sound.

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 ▶ 56–57 Intervals
 ▶ 194–195 Phrasing and phrase marks
 Keyboards 198–199 ▶

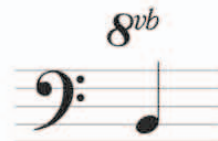
Range and octave information

Sometimes composers may want a performer to play something particularly high, or at the top of an instrument's range. They might also want something to be played at the very bottom of an instrument's range. Notating these extreme ranges on the staves requires many ledger lines, which can be difficult to read.



△ Ottava

The marking 8va stands for the Italian word “octave,” and when printed above the staff it means to play a note one octave (8 notes) higher than it is written.



△ Ottava bassa

The marking 8vb means *ottava bassa*, and indicates to perform notes one octave lower. It is sometimes notated with an 8va marking below the notes.

▷ Playing 8va

Here, the sounding pitches look awkward in ledger lines; notating them on the staff with the 8va marking is a clearer direction.



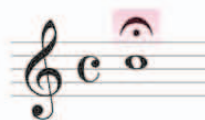
▷ Playing 8vb

The pitches to be played on the bass clef are not easy to read below the staff. It is better to place them on the staff and indicate 8vb.



Hold and pause

In music, it is important to have places where forward motion ceases, and where time is held in suspension for a moment. These dramatic breaks and stops are usually indicated with a fermata or pause sign—known colloquially as a “bird’s eye”—or a caesura.



◁ Fermata or pause

A fermata calls for the performer to hold a note longer than its specified value. It is often used to create a sound of finality at the end of a section.

Caesura is notated by two diagonal lines



◁ Caesura

A caesura is a brief pause of an undefined amount and is open to interpretation. Because it represents a complete stop in musical motion, musicians informally call it “railroad tracks.”